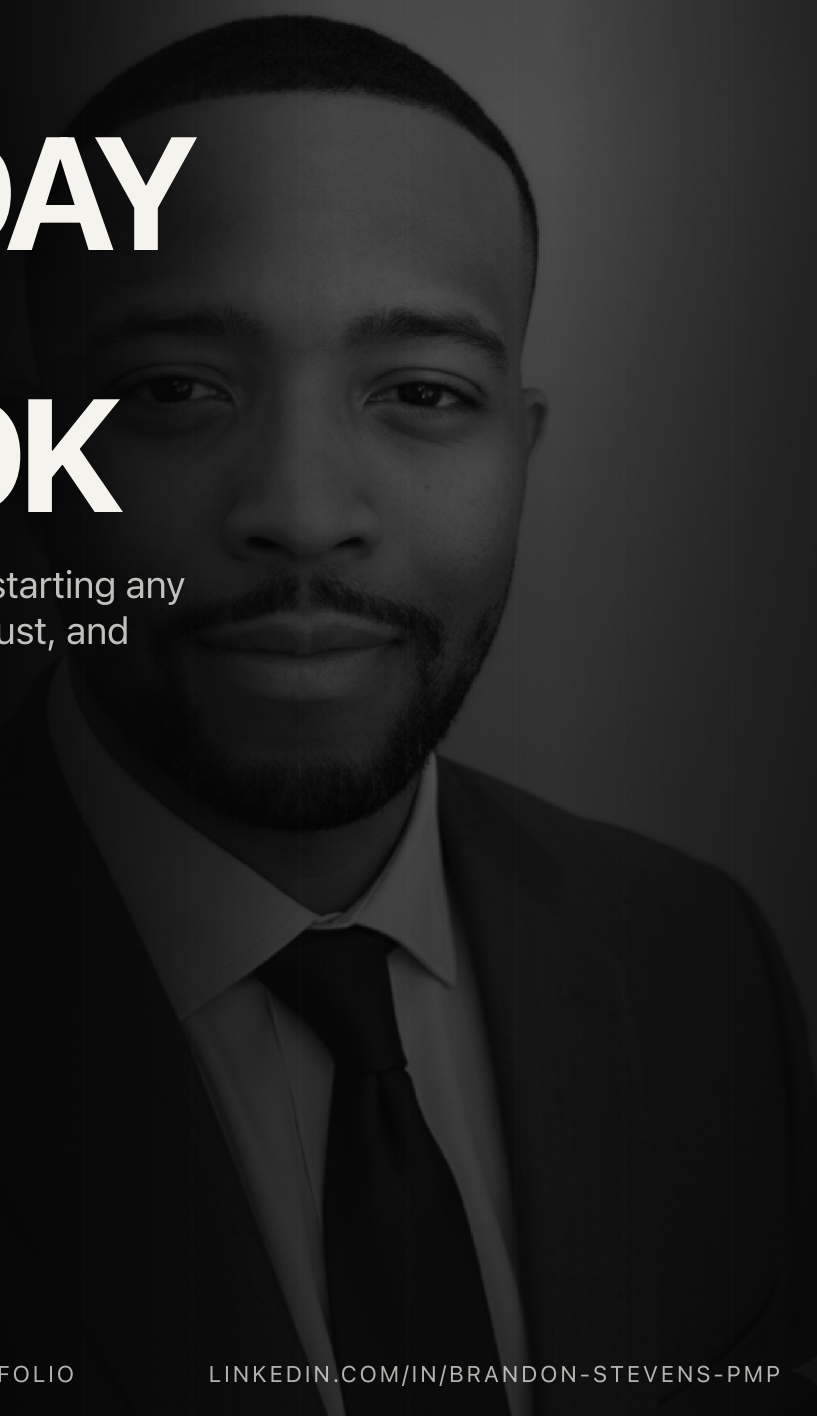


A grayscale portrait of Brandon Stevens, a man with a beard and mustache, wearing a suit and tie, looking directly at the camera. The portrait is positioned on the right side of the page, partially overlapping the title text.

THE 90-DAY NEW PM PLAYBOOK

A week-by-week operating system for starting any project management role with clarity, trust, and momentum.

YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS

The first 90 days are not about proving you know everything. They are about proving you can learn fast, communicate clearly, and create trust.

This playbook is designed for new PMs, senior PMs changing teams, contractors starting a client engagement, or anyone inheriting an active portfolio. It avoids employer-specific language and focuses on repeatable operating habits.

Phase	Days	Primary goal	How you are judged
Listen	1-30	Understand before changing	Do you ask sharp questions and respect context?
Align	31-60	Create rhythm and trust	Do people know what to expect from you?
Own	61-90	Deliver a visible outcome	Can you move work without drama?

THE 13-WEEK PLAN

Use this as a checklist. Adapt the timing, but do not skip the logic.

Week	Theme	Primary outcome
Week 1	Orient	Collect context, meet your manager, find every artifact, build a stakeholder list.
Week 2	Listen	Run structured 1:1s with direct stakeholders. Ask the same core questions.
Week 3	Map	Map process flow, decision rights, risks, dependencies, and informal influence.
Week 4	Synthesize	Send a 30-day findings memo and align on 60/90-day outcomes.
Week 5	Cadence	Set meeting rhythm, status format, escalation path, and decision log.
Week 6	Trust	Deliver one small reliability win: cleaner notes, clearer dashboard, faster blocker resolution.
Week 7	Govern	Clarify scope/change process and confirm how decisions are documented.
Week 8	Prioritize	Create a ranked worklist using value, urgency, risk, and effort.
Week 9	Own	Select one visible 90-day win and define acceptance criteria.
Week 10	Execute	Drive the win with weekly stakeholder updates and blocker management.
Week 11	Stabilize	Close loops, document changes, and remove lingering ambiguity.
Week 12	Measure	Capture before/after outcomes, adoption evidence, and lessons learned.
Week 13	Review	Deliver a 90-day review memo and propose the next 90-day plan.

DAYS 1-30: LISTEN

Earn the right to have opinions.

The fastest way to lose trust is to recommend changes before you understand why the current system exists. Spend the first month learning the formal process, the informal process, and the difference between them.

Listening-tour question	What it reveals
What does success look like in the next six months?	Goal alignment
What is working that I should protect?	Current strengths
Where does work most often get stuck?	Operational friction
Who do I need to build trust with?	Influence map
What should I know that may not be obvious?	Hidden context
What did the last PM do well or poorly?	Operating instructions

30-DAY FINDINGS MEMO

WHAT I LEARNED

TOP RISKS

TOP OPPORTUNITIES

STAKEHOLDER THEMES

MANAGER QUESTIONS

DAYS 31-60: ALIGN

Turn learning into operating rhythm.

Cadence	Purpose	Output
Daily	Review blockers and near-term commitments	Updated action log
Weekly	Team status and risk review	One-page status update
Biweekly	Manager alignment	Decisions and escalations
Monthly	Sponsor or portfolio review	Executive summary

DEFINE YOUR PM BRAND

Your PM brand is what people reliably get when they work with you. Choose it intentionally: clear communication, no surprises, early risks, decision-ready options, and consistent follow-through.

MANAGER ALIGNMENT

WHAT DOES
SUCCESS LOOK
LIKE?

WHAT DECISIONS
CAN I MAKE?

PREFERRED STATUS
FORMAT

TOP STAKEHOLDER

BIGGEST HIDDEN
RISK

DAYS 61-90: OWN

Choose one clean win and finish it well.

A strong 90-day win is visible, achievable, aligned to a real priority, and evidence-backed. It does not need to be huge. It needs to be complete.

Win filter	Question
Visibility	Will the right stakeholders notice?
Feasibility	Can it be completed in 30 days?
Value	Does it reduce risk, save time, or clarify decisions?
Ownership	Can you personally drive it?
Evidence	Can you prove the before/after difference?

90-DAY WIN CHARTER

WIN STATEMENT

STAKEHOLDERS

ACCEPTANCE
CRITERIA

RISKS

WEEKLY MILESTONES

EVIDENCE OF
COMPLETION

CORE TEMPLATES

Simple tools beat complicated theater.

Template	Purpose	Minimum fields
Stakeholder map	Know who matters and why	Name, role, influence, interest, goal, comms preference
Risk register	Surface issues early	Risk, probability, impact, owner, response, trigger
Decision log	Prevent circular debates	Decision, owner, date, options, rationale
Action log	Keep commitments visible	Action, owner, due date, status
Status update	Create trust at scale	RAG, wins, risks, decisions needed, next milestones

WEEKLY PM RESET

WHAT MOVED?

WHAT IS BLOCKED?

WHAT DECISION IS NEEDED?

WHAT CHANGED?

WHO NEEDS TO KNOW?

YOUR 90-DAY REVIEW

Do not walk into your review with vibes. Bring evidence.

- 1. Restate what you were asked to accomplish.
- 2. Show what you completed with proof.
- 3. Name the relationships and systems you built.
- 4. Explain what you learned about the organization.
- 5. Identify the next 90-day priorities.

90-DAY REVIEW MEMO

ORIGINAL
EXPECTATIONS

COMPLETED
OUTCOMES

METRICS/EVIDENCE

LESSONS LEARNED

NEXT 90-DAY PLAN

BRANDON STEVENS, PMP

FINAL NOTE

A strong start is built on curiosity, discipline, and follow-through.

The best PMs do not win the first 90 days by performing confidence. They win by creating clarity where there was noise, trust where there was uncertainty, and movement where work had stalled.

Use this playbook weekly. Keep it visible. Let it become your operating system.

— Brandon Stevens, PMP